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Christianity In The Age Of Algorithms



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BY JOE HAWKINS/PROPHECY RECON JUNE 01, 2026

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The New Pulpit

Not long ago, discipleship primarily happened through the local church, faithful pastors, family devotions, and personal Bible study. Believers gathered together, sat under sound teaching, and matured through relationships with other Christians. Spiritual growth was often a slower process. One built around reading, reflection, prayer, and learning from those who had walked with Christ longer than they had.

While those things still exist today, a significant shift has taken place. The average Christian now lives in a world saturated with digital content. Before many people open their Bibles in the morning, they reach for a phone. Before hearing from a pastor on Sunday, they may have already consumed dozens of videos, podcasts, memes, and social media posts. The modern believer often enters a worship service after spending hours immersed in a completely different information environment.

Something else has quietly entered the discipleship process.

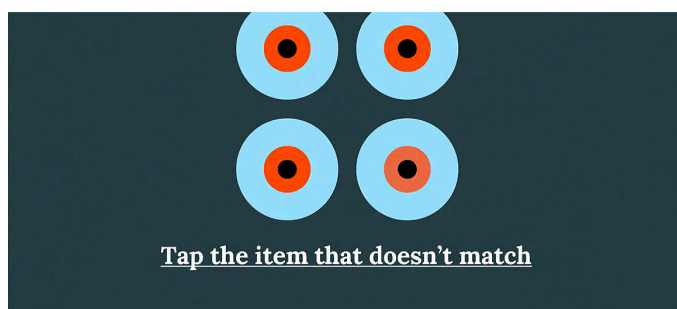
The smartphone has become a constant companion, and the social feed increasingly functions as a type of digital pulpit. Every swipe introduces ideas, values, fears, opinions, and worldviews. The issue is not merely that people are consuming more information than previous generations; it is that invisible systems now determine much of what they see.

Those systems are called algorithms.

Unlike a pastor who prayerfully prepares a message or a teacher who intentionally builds a lesson, algorithms are designed around a different objective. Their purpose is not spiritual maturity. Their purpose is attention. They are designed to learn what captures us, what keeps us watching, and what prevents us from moving on to something else.

That reality raises an important question for Christians: If something is constantly shaping our thoughts, then who (or what) is teaching our minds?





Attention Has Become a Battlefield

The battle for truth has always involved the mind. Scripture repeatedly warns believers about deception, false teaching, and conformity to worldly thinking. Romans 12:2 tells believers, "And do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind..." The battlefield of spiritual warfare has never simply been external; it has always involved what people believe and how they think.

What makes our present moment unique is that the competition for attention has become relentless.

Modern platforms are built around systems that study user behavior. Every pause on a video, every click on an article, every search, and every interaction becomes data. Algorithms learn preferences and then serve increasingly personalized content designed to maximize engagement. If a user watches several videos involving political outrage, more outrage appears. If they stop on conspiracy content, more conspiracy content follows. If they linger on something inappropriate, more inappropriate stories begin filling their feed.

The system simply gives people more of what appears to hold their attention.

Research in recent years has increasingly suggested that emotionally charged and sensational content often spreads more effectively online than carefully reasoned information. This creates a troubling dynamic because truth and engagement are not necessarily the same thing. Truth frequently requires patience, context, and thoughtful consideration. Emotional reactions, however, happen almost instantly.

The result is a culture increasingly conditioned to react before thinking.

For believers, this should create concern because spiritual maturity has never been built on immediate reactions. Growth in Christ often develops through slow and intentional practices: reading Scripture, praying, studying doctrine, spending time in fellowship, and allowing God's Word to transform the mind over time.

The digital world increasingly trains people in the opposite direction.





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The Rise of Fast-Food Theology

The influence of algorithms extends beyond entertainment and politics; it increasingly shapes theology itself.

Many Christians today consume biblical teaching in the same way they consume every other form of online content. Instead of sustained study, theology can become fragmented into short clips and brief emotional moments. Sermons become thirty-second videos. Complex doctrine becomes condensed into catchy quotes. Difficult passages become reduced to simplistic explanations.

Short-form content is not inherently bad. God can certainly use brief messages to encourage believers or point someone toward truth. A short video may inspire a person to study a passage further or introduce them to a teaching they might otherwise miss.

Problems emerge, however, when snippets replace substance.

There is a significant difference between hearing a thirty-second motivational clip and studying an entire chapter of Scripture within its context. There is a difference between watching a highlight and understanding the complete message. Sound doctrine requires depth, and depth takes time.

Recent concerns about shortened attention patterns have only intensified these discussions. Many researchers and educators continue observing increasing difficulty among younger generations in maintaining sustained focus amid constant digital stimulation. Whether scrolling through endless videos or rapidly switching between applications, attention increasingly becomes fragmented.

Spiritually speaking, this creates important questions.

If believers become accustomed to consuming information in ten-second increments, what happens when they are asked to sit quietly and meditate on Scripture? What happens when prayer feels slow? What happens when studying an entire book of the Bible requires more effort than scrolling through dozens of videos?

Psalm 1 describes the righteous person as someone who delights in God's law and meditates upon it day and night. Meditation requires concentration and stillness. Yet stillness has become increasingly rare in a world filled with notifications and constant stimulation.





Technology as a Spiritual Authority

Recent developments involving artificial intelligence have introduced an entirely new dimension to these concerns.

Throughout the past year, multiple reports have highlighted people increasingly using AI systems for emotional support, life advice, and even spiritual guidance. Some users have described AI systems in surprisingly personal terms, seeking comfort, affirmation, and meaning through conversations with machines.

Technology has always served practical purposes, and artificial intelligence can certainly provide useful information and assistance. Yet Christians should recognize an important distinction. Technology is meant to be a tool, not a source of ultimate authority.

Human beings have always looked somewhere for guidance and meaning. Historically, people sought wisdom through family, tradition, religion, philosophy, or trusted relationships. Increasingly, however, many individuals now turn first toward digital systems.

This becomes concerning because algorithms and artificial intelligence do not possess spiritual discernment. They cannot convict sin. They cannot produce genuine wisdom. They cannot replace the ministry of the Holy Spirit.

Scripture describes God's Word as "living and active and sharper than any two-edged sword" (Hebrews 4:12). The Bible does not merely comfort people; it confronts them. It exposes pride, reveals sin, and calls believers toward repentance and transformation.

Algorithms function differently.

Rather than confronting people, they frequently reinforce preferences. Instead of challenging assumptions, they often amplify them. Instead of exposing blind spots, they commonly provide more of what users already enjoy. A virtual tickling of the ear.

That creates a kind of digital echo chamber where people increasingly hear reflections of themselves.

Spiritual growth, however, rarely happens inside echo chambers.

Guarding the Mind in a Digital World

None of this means believers should abandon technology altogether. Social media and digital platforms can spread the gospel, encourage believers, and connect believers around the world in ways previous generations never experienced. Ministries can reach millions of people instantly. Biblical resources have become available at unprecedented levels.

Technology itself is not the enemy. The greater issue involves stewardship.

Believers must ask whether they are controlling technology or whether technology is controlling them. The issue is not whether someone owns a smartphone. The issue is whether the smartphone increasingly owns their attention.

Perhaps Christians need to periodically examine themselves by asking difficult questions.

How much time am I spending in God's Word compared to scrolling through content? What voices influence me most each day? Am I consuming more opinions than Scripture? Am I pursuing truth or simply pursuing whatever captures my attention?

Those questions matter because discipleship is rarely neutral.





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Those words may carry even greater significance in the age of algorithms.

The modern world is filled with endless voices competing for attention. Yet followers of Christ must remember that not every voice deserves authority over their minds. The Church cannot allow social feeds to become its primary teachers. Believers cannot allow algorithms to replace biblical discipleship.

Because if Christians are not intentionally being shaped by God's Word, something else will gladly do the shaping for them.

And increasingly, that something may be sitting in the palm of our hands.

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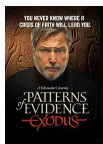
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